

Practice Quiz: Cognition (Philosophical Foundations)

Name: __ Date: __

Part A: Multiple Choice

1. The "4E" framework refers to cognition as: A) Four stages of development B) Embodied, Embedded, Enacted, and Extended C) Four brain regions D) Four types of inference
2. Radical enactivism objects to Active Inference because: A) Active Inference is too simple B) Active Inference relies on generative *models* — a form of internal representation that enactivism rejects C) Active Inference doesn't involve action D) Enactivism rejects all science
3. The Markov Blanket paradox for the extended mind is: A) MBs are always wrong B) If MBs define cognitive boundaries, they seem to *prevent* cognitive extension by separating internal from external C) MBs are too large D) The extended mind is impossible
4. "Nested Markov Blankets" resolve the extension problem by: A) Ignoring the problem B) Showing that at different scales, different systems (brain, brain+tool, group) each have their own blankets C) Eliminating all boundaries D) Making blankets smaller
5. Autopoiesis and the FEP converge because: A) Both are about robots B) Both emphasize self-organization, operational closure, and the circularity of living systems C) Neither involves mathematics D) Both reject embodiment
6. Cognitive niche construction means: A) Building physical niches only B) Organisms modify their environment to reduce future surprise — extending and supporting their generative models C) Random environmental change D) Computer programming
7. Active Inference's relationship to enactivism is best characterized as: A) Complete agreement B) Productive tension — Active Inference formalizes enactivist insights but retains representational vocabulary C) Total incompatibility D) Active Inference replaces enactivism

Part B: Essay Questions

1. "Active Inference is enactive inference." Evaluate Ramstead et al.'s (2020) claim. Does formalizing enactivist ideas in representational mathematics genuinely honor the enactivist program, or does it betray it? (300 words)
2. Apply the extended mind thesis to a concrete technology (e.g., smartphone, AI assistant). Where is the Markov Blanket? Is the user's cognition "extended" into the device? What are the philosophical implications? (300 words)
3. Design a philosophical argument for or against "Cultural Markov Blankets" — the idea that social institutions create group-level statistical boundaries supporting collective cognition. Use at least one concrete example. (300 words)